DIBURIM

Reflections on Sefer Devarim

From Self to Surrender: A Journey Through Elul and Tishrei

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Volume I: Sefer Devarim

Diburim (דִּבּוּרִים) — "Spoken Words"

This series captures divrei Torah originally spoken and recorded,
then transcribed and refined into written form.

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INTRODUCTION

Why I wrote this

Over the last several months, I've had the opportunity to work on a series of Divrei Torah that eventually came together into this *Kuntres*, now called **Diburim** — reflections based on *Sefer Devarim*. The name *Diburim* holds a dual meaning. It echoes *Sefer Devarim*—the Book of "Words"—and also the living "speech" through which these Torah thoughts began. I'm not much of a writer but rather an orator. Each piece of this started as spoken words which I first recorded and then transcribed and refined. In this way, I am able to connect my talents to Torah, *as living conversation*.

Sefer Devarim, often called *Mishneh Torah*, the "second telling" of the Torah, has always stood out to me as more than a review. In it, Hashem, through Moshe Rabbeinu, reframes the Torah's deepest lessons, speaking not to history alone but directly to the Jewish heart.

This project grew out of questions and encouragement, from friends, mentors, and fellow seekers who share a similar *hashkafah*, yet also wrestle with that focal question: *How do I connect with Hashem?* Is it about my own journey, or about others? How do I live as a Jew in a complex and changing world?

Throughout this journey, I've woven together the teachings of many *Rabbanim* I've learned from, especially my two most direct and influential teachers, **Rabbi Yehoshua Gerzi** and **Rabbi Don Channen**, whose wisdom, authenticity, and depth have guided both my connection with Hashem in a practical but heartfelt way.

The goal of *Diburim* is simple: to help each reader find themselves within the words of *Devarim*, to make mitzvot personal, to draw Hashem's presence into daily life, and to turn Torah learning into a living, breathing relationship.

As *Sefer Devarim* bridges the Torah's story toward entry into Eretz Yisrael, so too *Diburim* seeks to bridge reflection and renewal, from self to surrender, from speech to connection and from a me focussed reality to a them focussed reality.

Interestingly, this is my first attempt at such a work and as feedback from my friends and mentors have reflected, even I see the change in myself from parsha to parsha, activity to activity and goal to goal. I hope you all find as much growth in this work and reading it as I have experienced in putting it together.

From Self to Surrender: Walking the Journey of Devarim

Sefer Devarim is more than the closing of the Torah — it is a mirror that reflects who we are and who we are becoming. From Moshe Rabbeinu's final words to our own preparation for Elul and Tishrei, the sefer guides us from self-awareness to self-transcendence, from ownership to offering, from ego to emunah.

Each *parsha* in *Devarim* poses a simple but searching question: **Where am I in relation to Hashem's will?** Through Moshe's review and rebuke, we are reminded that the struggles of the desert — fear, complaint, forgetfulness — still echo within us, yet so too do the faith and gratitude that carried us forward.

As we read *Devarim* in Elul, the words become tools for *cheshbon hanefesh* — a spiritual language for return and renewal. The flow of the sefer mirrors the inner journey:

- **Devarim** opens with memory and responsibility.
- **Va'etchanan** calls us to uproot inner idolatry.
- **Eikev** turns our focus to the "small" mitzvot.
- **Re'eh** teaches generosity and awareness.
- **Shoftim** and **Ki Tetzei** provide Elul's structure.
- **Ki Tavo** and **Nitzavim** culminate in gratitude and unity.

From there, we arrive at the Yamim Nora'im and Sukkot — living out what we've learned. By *Simchat Torah*, we've not just finished the Torah; we've completed a circle of growth.

How to Use This Kuntres

This *kuntres* is not just a commentary, but a guide for reflection and connection. Each *parsha* closes with brief questions and practices, simple prompts to translate insight into action. Take them slowly. Let the words meet you where you are. This is the journey from self to surrender.

PART I: THE PARSHIYOT OF SEFER DEVARIM

CHAPTER 1

PARASHAT DEVARIM — Not Just Their Story, Ours Too

This week's parsha, Parshat Devarim, is the opening of the final book of the Torah — Sefer Devarim. It's not just a new parsha; it marks a dramatic shift in tone and perspective.

Here, Moshe Rabbeinu stands at the end of his life. He's not commanding the people with new laws. Instead, he's speaking personally — from the heart. What we hear in these chapters is what many mefarshim describe as Moshe's "ethical will," his final words to a generation poised to enter the land of Israel without him.

Rav Yisroel Gordon zt"l of Los Angeles used to call Sefer Devarim "Moshe Rabbeinu's Last Will and Testament." That's exactly what it is. Moshe knows the end is near. He gathers Bnei Yisrael — like a grandfather calling his family to his bedside — and begins to speak.

But what does he say?

He doesn't tell them, "Everything will be fine." He doesn't sugarcoat history. He starts with tochacha, rebuke. He reminds them of all the ways that the nation failed in the Midbar: the sin of the Meraglim, the complaints, the power struggles, the hesitations, the missed opportunities.

And yet — this new generation was not there. These weren't the ones who cried on the night of Tisha B'Av after the Meraglim. They weren't the ones who asked for meat or rebelled against Moshe. All of that took place decades earlier, mostly within the first two years after leaving Egypt. Those who participated have already died in the desert.

So why is Moshe rebuking this generation? Because this is not just history. This is memory — and in Judaism, memory is not passive. It's a living inheritance.

Like a Grandfather on His Deathbed

Think of a father or grandfather lying on their bed, surrounded by family, about to leave this world. He doesn't just tell his children stories. He shares experiences, values, and warnings. He says, "This is what we went through. This is where we stumbled. Don't make the same mistakes." There's no anger. There's no shame. There's just the deep hope that the next generation will learn from the past.

Moshe is doing the same. He's telling this generation: "You're about to enter the land. You'll face challenges. And I want you to remember — even your parents and grandparents, who saw open miracles, who had Hashem right in front of them — they still fell. Don't be arrogant. Don't be naïve. Learn from them."

Not Shame — Strength

Moshe doesn't tell them this to belittle or berate them. He tells them this to empower them. Yes, even those who had direct access to Hashem — who stood at Har Sinai, who ate the mann, who drank from Miriam's well — even they were human. Even they failed. So don't assume you're above failing. And don't be ashamed of their failures either. Embrace them. Learn from them. Be strengthened by them.

This is the Torah's view of national memory. It isn't edited or whitewashed. We include the hard parts — and we own them.

Viduy: We and Our Fathers

We see this especially in viduy, our confessional prayer. Whether said daily or a few times a year, we include the line: "Aval anachnu v'avoteinu chatanu" (אבל אנחנו ואבותינו חטאנו) — "But we and our fathers have sinned." Why do we confess our ancestors' sins? Because the Torah teaches us that we're not disconnected individuals floating in time. We are part of a chain, bound by memory and mission. The past shapes us — and we carry its lessons forward. It's not about guilt. It's about honesty.

"Ki ein anachnu azei fanim u'kshei oref lomar… Tzaddikim anachnu v'lo chatanu…" (כי אין אנחנו עזי פנים וקשי ערף לומר... צדיקים אנחנו ולא חטאנו) — "We are not brazen-faced or stiff-necked to say: We are righteous and have not sinned…" No — we acknowledge what we've done. And we also acknowledge what those before us did. That's part of what keeps us grounded, humble, and on track.

Preparing for Eretz Yisrael — and for Tisha B'Av

Moshe's message is especially relevant as we approach Tisha B'Av. We know this is a time of mourning — for the Temples, for exile, for tragedies across Jewish history. But it's also a time of truth. We remind ourselves, year after year, not just of what happened — but of why it happened. We review the sins that led to destruction, not to crush ourselves with guilt, but to awaken ourselves to the task ahead.

Eretz Yisrael is not just a gift. It's a responsibility. The Torah calls it "a land that vomits out its inhabitants" if they become corrupt. We have to be worthy of it.

Moshe is telling us: "You are going to inherit the land. Don't inherit it blindly. Inherit it with eyes wide open. Know what happened before — and choose better."

Final Message

As we head into Shabbat Chazon, the Shabbat before Tisha B'Av, we're asked to look deeply at our past and also forward to our future. Yes, there have been failures. But there has also been teshuvah. And hope. And rebuilding. And return.

Moshe Rabbeinu's final message to the people — and to us — is not one of despair. It's a call to responsibility. And a vote of confidence. "You know what happened before. You've seen the consequences. Now take the next step. And do it better."

May this Shabbos be not just a time of mourning, but of vision. A Shabbat of chazon — of clarity. A Shabbat where we carry the past with us not as a burden — but as a compass. And may we merit to rebuild.

Reflection Questions

- What patterns from my past keep repeating? What am I being called to learn from them?
- Where in my life am I refusing to "own" my family or community's history?
- How can I carry the lessons of the past as a compass rather than a burden?

Shabbat Shalom.

CHAPTER 2

PARASHAT VA'ETCHANAN — Climbing Out of the Shadows of Avodah Zarah

Parashat Va'etchanan is packed with foundational themes: Avodah Zarah (idolatry), the repetition of the Aseret HaDibrot (Ten Commandments), and the Shema. While these sections

are often viewed in isolation, there's a deep thread connecting them — a spiritual journey upward, guiding us from the lowest human impulses to the highest levels of Divine connection.

Let's begin with Avodah Zarah. Classically, idolatry is understood as the worship of foreign gods. But the Ba'al Shem Tov and other Chassidic masters redefine it as anything we place between ourselves and Hashem. Anger, for example, is described as a form of idolatry — when we lose our temper, we are declaring that our will is supreme, that reality should bend to our desires, not Hashem's. The Gemara (Shabbat 105b) tells us: "Kol ha-ko'es, ke'ilu oved avodah zarah" (כל הכועס כאילו עובד עבודה זרה) — "Anyone who gets angry, it is as if they have worshipped idols."

The Gemara further teaches (Avodah Zarah 12a) that even the appearance of idolatry is prohibited. If someone bends down to remove a thorn in front of an idol, even unintentionally, it's problematic if onlookers could misconstrue the act. Why such strictness? Because Ani Hashem Elokecha — "I am Hashem your God" (Devarim 5:6) — demands that we live with constant awareness of Hashem's presence. The path to true emunah requires radical honesty and vigilance over even the subtlest disconnects.

There is another layer to why this matters so urgently: we are not private souls wandering alone — we are a holy people with a holy job. The Torah calls Klal Yisrael a "mamlechet kohanim v'goy kadosh" (ממלכת כהנים וגוי קדוש) (Exodus 19:6) and the prophets envision us as an "or lagoyim" (אור לגויים) — a light unto the nations (Isaiah 42:6).

That mission means our inner life carries public weight: our anger, jealousy, and petty idolatries not only harm our character but dim the witness we are meant to bring into the world. The commandments, the Shema, and the whole moral architecture of the Torah are training us to be visibly different — not in order to withdraw, but in order to model a way of life that points others toward Hashem. In short: holiness is both personal purification and public service; failing in one weakens the other.

Let's now return to the Aseret HaDibrot, the Ten Commandments. They open with the highest statement of truth — Hashem as our Redeemer from Mitzrayim — but they conclude on what seems like a much more "human" level: Lo Tachmod — Do not covet.

At first glance, jealousy seems far less severe than idolatry or murder. But perhaps that's exactly the point. Coveting arises from a distorted vision — a life lived through the eyes of "what I lack" rather than "what Hashem has given me." It's a fundamentally self-centered worldview, one that can spiral into resentment, dishonesty, and yes, even idolatry.

As Rashi explains on Bamidbar (Numbers) 15:39: "העין רואה והלב חומד" — "The eye sees and the heart desires." The Torah warns us that spiritual downfall often begins not with the outward act, but with what we allow into our gaze: vision shapes desire, and desire, unchecked, too often shapes action.

Yet the ladder of the Aseret HaDibrot offers a way up. After jealousy, the previous commandment is Lo Tirtzach — Do not murder. As jarring as it sounds, this is already a step

above jealousy. Why? Because it's no longer just inner emotion — it's action, however misguided. From there, the commandments move upward through theft, false witness, and ultimately to Kibbud Av Va'eim, the honoring of parents — the first (as we work backwards) "positive" commandment that builds trust in societal and spiritual structure.

Above this is Shabbat, the sanctification of time and the affirmation that Hashem is the Creator. And from there, we reach the peak: "Anochi Hashem Elokecha" — total recognition of Divine unity and providence.

But Va'etchanan doesn't stop there. It immediately continues into the Shema, perhaps the Torah's clearest declaration of Divine oneness:

"Shema Yisrael, Hashem Elokeinu, Hashem Echad." (שמע ישראל ה' אלהינו ה' אחד)

The Gemara in Berachot (13b) teaches that when we say "Echad," we should expand the word. Many commentators explain this to mean to reflect on Hashem's unity in all realms — heaven, earth, all directions.

The third letter is Daled, numerical value "four," which denotes the four directions of the horizontal plane: north, south, east, west. Chet, numerical value "eight," signifies the seven heavens and the earth, the vertical plane, including all spiritual dimensions. Aleph, which has the numerical value "one," refers to G-d Himself. Everything we experience, every challenge or joy, is part of that.

The Shema invites us to take everything we've learned — from the dangers of idolatry, to the self-discipline of the Ten Commandments — and internalize it until it becomes our essence. Not just obedience, but devotion. Not just avoiding sin, but becoming a vessel for Hashem's presence in the world.

The Avot — Avraham, Yitzchak, and Yaakov — are described as the Merkavah, the chariot of the Divine. They lived in such harmony with Hashem's will that they became vehicles of it. That level is daunting. But the Torah believes we can climb there — step by step, dibrah by dibrah, kri'ah by kri'ah.

And so we ask ourselves this week:

Am I still at the level of desire and jealousy? Am I struggling with emotional reactions like anger or resentment? Am I moving into action — building positive habits, sanctifying my time, honoring my parents, recognizing Hashem's gifts?

Because only by climbing these steps can we arrive at the true Ani Hashem Elokecha, and from there, to the clarity and peace of Shema Yisrael.

Reflection Questions

- Am I still at the level of desire and jealousy, or am I moving toward recognizing Hashem's gifts?
- What "small" idolatries do I place between myself and Hashem? (Anger, resentment, control?)
- When I say the Shema, do I truly reflect on Hashem's unity in all directions of my life?

CHAPTER 3

PARASHAT EIKEV — Don't Step on the Small Things

This week's parasha, Eikev, is filled with amazing little messages — and if you'll excuse the pun, they shouldn't be "stepped on." The very word eikev means "heel." Rashi (Devarim 7:12, s.v. vehaya eikev tishme'un) tells us that this hints to mitzvot that people tend to tread upon with their heels — mitzvot that are easy to forget, that we step over without even thinking, the things that seem so small or insignificant that they barely register in our minds.

But why are these "heel mitzvot" so important? If we think back to last week's parasha, Va'etchanan, we read the Shema — the moment where we declare that my will is nothing compared to Hashem's will, and my goal is to be mevatel (nullify) my own ratzon to His ratzon. If I'm truly in that mindset, then who am I to decide which mitzvah matters to Hashem and which one doesn't? The truth is, Hashem has already told us what matters. He gave us the Torah, the Shulchan Aruch, the Mishnah Berurah, and the wisdom of our sages to guide us. These mitzvot — even the ones that seem small — are part of His plan for us. If they're in the Torah, they matter.

Bringing the small into awareness

The real question is: if these mitzvot are so easy to forget, how do we bring them back into our conscious awareness? The Baal Shem Tov teaches that hashgacha pratit — Individual Divine Providence — is revealed in our lives to the degree that we are aware of the small details of our actions. When a Jew trains himself to notice and sanctify even the smallest moments, he opens himself to seeing Hashem's hand everywhere.

I once learned this teaching through an example connected to the mikveh. When preparing to immerse, a chossid asked his Rebbi, what kavanot should I have when going to the mikve. The Rebbe responded based on this teaching to start being aware even before you get near the water. As you take off your shoes, think: "I am taking off my shoes in preparation for the mikveh." When you remove your socks, think: "I am removing my socks in preparation for going into the mikve." Step by step, be aware everything you are doing and that what you are doing is part of a holy act. Why? Because as Hashem said to Moshe Rabbeinu to relay to the Jewish People, "You shall be holy, for I, your G-d, am holy." (קדשים תהיו כי קדוש אני ה' אלהיכם) (Vayikra 19:2). When we learn to pay attention to these small acts, not just the "big" mitzvot but the little

ones, we bring them to the forefront of our minds. They stop being background noise and start being acts of connection to Hashem.

Even the way you tie your shoes

Halachah itself reflects this mindset. The Shulchan Aruch (Orach Chaim 2:4) teaches that there is an order for putting on shoes: right shoe first, then left, but tie the left first (Shabbos 61a), as a reminder of the way we bind tefillin on our left arm. Think about that: something as mundane as putting on your shoes can remind you of the covenant between you and Hashem. This is a perfect example of a "heel mitzvah", a small, almost hidden moment that can elevate your day. When I live with that awareness, the little things start to matter more and more. And when they matter to me, Hashem says: "If My small things matter to you, then you matter to Me."

The reward — and the warning

The Torah promises: "And it will be, because you will listen to these ordinances and keep them… Hashem your God will keep for you the covenant and the kindness… and He will love you and bless you and multiply you" (והיה עקב תשמעון... ושמר ה' אלהיך לך את הברית ואת החסד... ואהבך וברכך והרבך) (Devarim 7:12–13).

But Moshe also warns: "Lest you eat and be satisfied… and your heart will grow haughty, and you will forget Hashem your God" (פן תאכל ושבעת... ורם לבבך ושכחת את ה' אלהיך) (Devarim 8:12–14). The sefarim (and can be seen plainly in life) explain that when material blessings increase, there is a spiritual danger, we become distracted, and the small mitzvot are often the first to slip away. When that happens, Hashem may take away the blessing, not necessarily as a punishment, but as a loving reminder to reset, to bring us back to humility and awareness.

From the heel to the head — together

Later in the parasha we read Vehaya Im Shamoa (והיה אם שמע), the second paragraph of the Shema (Devarim 11:13–21). Many of the phrases echo the first paragraph, but there's a key difference: the first paragraph speaks in the singular (bechol levavcha - בכל לבבך), focusing on the individual's relationship with Hashem. The second paragraph speaks in the plural (bechol levavchem - בכל לבבכם), addressing the nation as a whole.

Rashi comments that bechol levavchem now implies the unity of everyone's hearts where previously it was on the individual. When we learn to value the small mitzvot, we also learn to value the "small" people, those who might be the "heels" of the nation, as us all having unified "hearts". The head and the heel are both essential to the body. The leaders and the simplest Jews are equally precious to Hashem. When we come together with our hearts, souls, and might united, then the blessings of Hashem can be complete.

So the message is simple, but it changes everything: Don't step on the little things. Whether it's a "small" mitzvah, a "small" person, or a "small" detail of life, Hashem treasures it all. If it

matters to Him, it should matter to us. And when we live that way, we become the people He wants us to be — from the head to the heel.

Reflection Questions

- Which "heel mitzvot" have I been stepping over? What small observances have I forgotten?
- How can I bring more awareness to mundane moments today?
- Who are the "small people" in my life that I've been overlooking or undervaluing?

Shabbat Shalom.

CHAPTER 4

PARASHAT RE'EH — Bracha, Avodah Zarah, and Tzedakah as One Path

Parshat Re'eh is packed with running themes that flow side by side. We begin with a dramatic and almost theatrical moment: the division of the tribes. Six tribes are stationed on Har Gerizim, six tribes on Har Eval, and the Levi'im together with the Kohanim stand in the valley between them. From that central place, they proclaim blessings to one side and curses to the other (Devarim 27:11–13). It's an image that sets the tone — the people literally positioned between bracha and klala.

But then the parsha moves quickly into other themes: strong warnings not to imitate the nations of the land, not to fall into the trap of avodah zarah, not to scar ourselves, not to distort Hashem's service. And finally, woven throughout, there is the recurring theme of giving: tzedakah, ma'aser, and supporting those in need.

At first glance, these might seem like three different topics: bracha and klala, avoiding avodah zarah, and giving tzedakah. But if we look closely, the Torah is interweaving them together into one continuous lesson for us.

Bracha and Klala – Two Perspectives on the Same Reality

The seforim on this concept make a powerful point: there isn't really such a thing as a klala in the absolute sense. There is revealed bracha — blessing that we can see and feel right away — and there is bracha that is not yet revealed, which appears to us as curse. In other words, what seems like klala is ultimately Hashem's way of redirecting us, warning us, correcting us.

A few weeks ago, we mentioned the idea that a klala can be understood as a kind of fatherly warning. If you see your child walking toward danger, you raise your voice, you stop them, you may even take something away from them. In that moment, the child may experience it as

harshness, as restriction, but later they understand it was an act of love. So too, Hashem gives us brachot that are open and sweet, and He also gives us reminders — which might look like klalot — that exist to keep us on the straight path.

So even at the beginning of the parsha, when half of the nation is facing Har Gerizim and half facing Har Eval, it's not that half the people are "bad" and half are "good." Rather, Hashem is laying before us the reality of life: we always stand between revealed blessing and hidden blessing.

The question is how we will see it, how we will interpret it, and whether we will allow those reminders to guide us.

Avodah Zarah – The Illusion of "Mine"

This perspective prepares us for the next great theme of the parsha: the command to avoid avodah zarah. Over and over, the Torah insists: "Do not be like the nations, do not serve their gods, do not follow their ways." Why? Because to be a Jew, first and foremost, means to know that Hashem is everything. Ein od milvado (אין עוד מלבדו). There is nothing else besides Him (Devarim 4:35).

When we forget this — when we believe our power, our success, our wealth is our own — then we start slipping into idolatry. The Gemara in Sanhedrin (64a) tells us that when Hashem removed the desire for avodah zarah, that destructive drive was replaced with a powerful desire for money.

In other words, the way people once related to idols — as ultimate sources of security, meaning, or identity — is now the way many people relate to wealth.

So when the Torah warns us against avodah zarah, it is not only talking about bowing down to statues. It is also warning us against bowing down to ourselves, to our own egos, to the illusion that "my strength and the might of my hand made me this wealth" (Devarim 8:17). That too is a form of idolatry.

Tzedakah and Ma'aser – Returning to Hashem What Is Already His

This brings us straight into the mitzvot of tzedakah and ma'aser. The Torah commands us to support the poor, the orphan, the widow, and the Levite who has no portion in the land. And Chazal elevate tzedakah to one of the greatest mitzvot, teaching that:

- "Tzedakah and acts of kindness are the equivalent of all the mitzvot of the Torah" – Jerusalem Talmud, Pe'ah 1:1
- "Greater is tzedakah than all the sacrifices" – Talmud, Sukkah 49b
- "If only the people who lived in the generation of the Flood and the people of Sodom had given tzedakah, they would not have perished" – Midrash Zutta, Song of Songs 1

- "Great is tzedakah, for since the day that the world was created until this day the world stands upon tzedakah" – Midrash Tanna d'Vei Eliyahu Zutta 1
- "Tzedakah saves from death" – Mishlei 10:2

Why does tzedakah have such power? Because giving corrects the illusion of idolatry. Giving breaks the ego that says, "It's mine."

Pirkei Avot (3:7) says: "Give Him from His own, for you and what is yours are His." (תן לו משלו שאתה ושלך שלו) When I give, I am not losing something that was mine. I am returning to Hashem what was already His in the first place.

The Torah itself emphasizes this: "It is Hashem Who gives you the strength to make wealth" (והוא הנתן לך כח לעשות חיל) (Devarim 8:18). My talents, my opportunities, my ability to work, the rain that makes crops grow, the economy that enables me to profit — all of it is a gift. Hashem says: I give you 100%, and I ask you to hold onto 90%. The other 10% — give it forward, to My people, to those I love, to those who cannot provide for themselves.

In this way, ma'aser and tzedakah are like modern korbanot. In the Beit HaMikdash, the fat and blood of the korban symbolized our own life-force, offered back to Hashem. Today, our money represents our "blood, sweat, and tears" — the work of our hands, our energy, our time. When we give it away, we are symbolically offering ourselves.

And unlike the nations who scar themselves or cut themselves as part of their rituals (Devarim 14:1), we serve Hashem in a healthy way: by giving, by supporting, by elevating. We don't harm ourselves; we lift others up.

Bracha or Klala – It's How We See

When I remember that money is a gift from Hashem, then my wealth becomes a bracha. When I forget, and I clutch it tightly, declaring "It's mine," then it turns into a klala. Not because Hashem wants to punish me, but because I have blinded myself to the Source, and I need to be reminded.

Like a parent who withholds something from a child not to hurt them but to protect them, Hashem sometimes sends us difficulties to bring us back. The Ramban explains that even what we perceive as curses are truly forms of divine love, designed to refine us and guide us.

And that circles back to the opening word of the parsha: Re'eh (ראה) — See. Hashem says: "See, I place before you today blessing and curse" (ראה אנכי נתן לפניכם היום ברכה וקללה) (Devarim 11:26). See — with your own eyes — that everything comes from Me. See that the choice is not about whether you will encounter blessing or curse, but about how you will understand and live with them.

Conclusion

So the parsha weaves together three themes into one message:

- **Bracha and klala** — life contains both, but both come from Hashem.
- **Avodah zarah** — idolatry is the illusion that something else is in control, especially money.
- **Tzedakah and ma'aser** — the antidote to idolatry, the act of returning to Hashem what is already His.

When we live this way, when we give generously, when we remember Ein Od Milvado, when we see challenges as hidden blessings — then we are truly standing on the mountain, in the place of bracha.

May we merit to always see Hashem's hand in everything, to give with joy, and to transform all that we have into revealed blessing.

Reflection Questions

- When I look at challenges in my life, can I reframe them as hidden blessings?
- Do I treat my resources as "mine" or as gifts from Hashem to steward?
- What would it look like to give tzedakah not out of obligation, but out of joy and gratitude?

Shabbat Shalom.

CHAPTER 5

PARASHAT SHOFTIM — Law, Order, and Holiness in the Everyday

Elul Connection – Ani L'dodi

We've just entered the month of Elul, a month known for preparation before Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur. The Sages teach that the very name Elul is hinted in the verse "Ani l'dodi v'dodi li" (אני לדודי ודודי לי) — I am my beloved's and my beloved is mine (Shir HaShirim 6:3).

This reminds us that our Avodat Hashem is not only about rules or fear of judgment, but about a relationship of love. Just as in a marriage, there are times when we do something not because it makes sense to us, but because our spouse desires it — so too with Hashem. There are mitzvot we cannot fully explain (chukim), yet we fulfill them as an act of devotion and love.

But Elul also reminds us that love is not enough on its own. A marriage also needs structure and order. There are times when we want things to make sense, or at least to see how they may shape life meaningfully. This is exactly where Parshat Shoftim comes in — providing the framework for a holy society.

Shoftim – Human Justice and Structure

This week, however, Parshat Shoftim opens from a different perspective. The very name — Shoftim, Judges — already brings us into the practical, human reality of how to structure society. It's not only about avoiding idolatry or foreign practices; it's about building a just and holy community.

"Shoftim v'shotrim titen lecha" (שפטים ושטרים תתן לך) — "You shall appoint judges and officers in all your gates" (Devarim 16:18). It is a mitzvah to establish courts and law enforcement in Eretz Yisrael, so that society does not descend into chaos (Sanhedrin 16b, Rambam Hilchot Sanhedrin 1:1).

As someone who grew up in America, I sometimes think of the "Wild West," where justice was inconsistent, duels took place in the street, and sheriffs often looked the other way. The Torah tells us: don't let that happen. Even something as "basic" as setting up judges and officers is in fact a godly act.

Impartial Justice – The Judge's Responsibility

The Torah emphasizes again and again the importance of impartial justice: "You shall not favor the poor, nor honor the great; with righteousness shall you judge your fellow" (לא תשא פני דל ולא תהדר פני גדול בצדק תשפט עמיתך) (Vayikra 19:15, cf. Devarim 1:17).

Pirkei Avot expands on this: a judge must not tilt judgment either way — not favoring the poor out of pity, and not honoring the wealthy out of respect. Justice must be blind.

The Torah goes further: "You shall not take a bribe" (לא תקח שחד) (Devarim 16:19). Rashi notes that even if the bribe would not change the outcome — even if the judge was going to rule the same way — he must remove himself from the case. Why? Because a bribe clouds perception. A judge who accepts influence, no matter how small, is no longer fit to rule. This is how Am Yisrael remains holy: not just in ritual, but in ensuring that our daily lives, our courts, and our leaders are untouched by corruption.

The King and His Torah

The next step of the things in the world which are normal, but which we need to keep in mind to do in a holy way in the parsha is the question of monarchy: "When you come to the land the Lord, your God, is giving you, and you possess it and live therein, and you say, 'I will set a king over myself, like all the nations around me,'" (כי תבא אל הארץ... ואמרת אשימה עלי מלך ככל הגוים) (Devarim 17:14). This request is not Hashem's ideal — after all, He Himself is our true King — but He permits it, with strict limits.

The king may not accumulate excessive horses, wealth, or wives (Devarim 17:16–17). Unlike the kings of the nations, who seek glory and indulgence, the Jewish king's task is service and humility. To safeguard this, the Torah commands that the king write for himself a personal Sefer

Torah and read from it constantly: "So that his heart not be lifted above his brethren" (לבלתי רום לבבו מאחיו) (17:19–20).

The Rambam (Hilchot Melachim 3:1) writes that the king carries this Torah wherever he goes. His authority is never for personal power but only to guide Am Yisrael under the authority of Torah.

These are all to remind us that even a King is still supposed to be subservient to Hashem. Unlike the kings of the nations, who pursue power, honor, and desire, the Jewish king's role is to serve Hashem and guide the people.

Prophets – True and False

Earlier in the Torah, the concern was primarily with Jews falsely claiming to speak in Hashem's name. Here the scope widens: we are warned even against prophets from among the nations, or those who use sorcery and witchcraft to predict the future.

Bilam is the classic example. He truly did hear Hashem's word, but he used it for selfish and corrupt purposes (Bamidbar 22–24). For the reasons of his motive was he brought down and punished, but he never prophesied for the Jews, only for the nations.

The bigger danger we are being warned of here is that prophecy outside of Torah is possible. In this parsha, the Torah contrasts false prophecy and kishuf with the true guidance of nevua and ruach hakodesh given to the Nevi'im of Am Yisrael. We see that while Hashem may choose to speak with some unique people of the nations of the world, even that can be confused with actions of Tumah.

The message is clear: don't be impressed by what looks powerful, mystical, or accurate. Truthfully, we don't even need to entertain those ways because there is always a kosher way, the Torah's way. Not because the other path lacks power, but because it lacks holiness. Just as the Jews had Moshe, Yehoshua and others to lead them then in the way of Torah, we have our guides and leaders now and here as well but just need to learn how to find them.

Witnesses and Testimony

Another foundation of justice in Shoftim is testimony: "By the testimony of two or three witnesses shall a matter be established" (על פי שנים עדים או שלשה עדים יקום דבר) (Devarim 19:15).

This principle ensures that justice is rooted in truth. False witnesses (eidim zomemim) are punished with the very sentence they hoped to impose on another (19:16–19). This safeguard keeps society from crumbling under lies and manipulation. Again, this is something other nations also recognize, but for us, it is not merely civic law — it is kedushah.

War and Bal Tashchit

Shoftim also addresses the laws of warfare. Even in battle, boundaries remain: we may not destroy fruit-bearing trees when laying siege: "For man is like the tree of the field" (כי האדם עץ השדה) (20:19). From here we learn the mitzvah of bal tashchit (בל תשחית) — the prohibition against needless destruction.

Sadly, in recent times we saw the opposite in Gush Katif, when flourishing orchards and greenhouses were destroyed rather than cherished. The Torah tells us: value Hashem's gifts. Even in the chaos of war, we are commanded to build, not destroy.

Further than this, we see another warning in action as well: if we act like those around us, the ones who should not be emulated, we may come to emulate the actions they do, even if they do not make sense in a bad way. We may act out of spite or anger and destroy without purpose, the ultimate descent to animalistic behaviors.

Stepping Out of the Midbar

All of these laws remind us of the transition taking place. Am Yisrael is leaving the midbar, where life was constant miracles — the manna, the clouds of glory, the Mishkan — and entering the land, where they will farm, fight wars, build courts, and appoint leaders.

And the Torah's message is this: holiness is not only in the Beit Midrash or the Mishkan. It must extend to the courtroom, the battlefield, the palace, and the orchard.

Conclusion – Finding Kedushah in the Mundane

This is the thread uniting both Elul and Shoftim. In Elul, we prepare ourselves to renew a relationship of love with Hashem: Ani l'dodi v'dodi li. Sometimes that love moves us to act beyond reason, and sometimes we see the sense and wisdom of Hashem's mitzvot. In Shoftim, we are reminded that even the rational, civic institutions of society — justice, kingship, courts, testimony, and even military conduct — are not just "practical." They are infused with kedushah when done in service of Hashem.

The nations of the world may also have courts, prophets, kings, and armies. But for us, every one of these is elevated — structured not by human whim, but by the Torah.

May we take this into Elul: to find kedushah in the ordinary, to align both our acts of love and our acts of order with the ratzon Hashem, and to enter the Yamim Nora'im ready to live as a truly holy people.

Reflection Questions

- Where in my life do I need to create better boundaries (ma'akeh) to protect holiness?
- Am I living with integrity both in public and in private?
- How can I bring kedushah into the "ordinary" structures of my day?

Due to length constraints, I need to continue the document in parts. Would you like me to continue adding the remaining chapters (Ki Tetzei through Sukkot, plus the Living These Teachings section and Conclusion)?

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PARASHAT KI TETZEI — A Checklist for Elul

This week's parsha, Ki Tetzei, is truly an amazing parsha. On a personal note, it was my Bar Mitzvah parsha, which already makes it meaningful to me. But beyond that, Ki Tetzei is remarkable because it falls at a very opportune time: we are in Elul, the month of cheshbon ha-nefesh, of taking stock of who I am, where I stand, where my growth has taken me, and where my alignment with Hashem's will should be going forward.

Ki Tetzei is also unique in another way: it is the sixth parsha in Sefer Devarim, which has eleven parshiyot total. That means it stands at the center point of the book. This is a perfect moment to pause, reflect on what has come before, and realign ourselves before moving forward.

A Quick Recap of the Journey in Devarim

In Devarim, Moshe began by reviewing the mistakes of the past and warning us not to repeat them. In Va'etchanan, we were called to align ourselves with Hashem's ratzon, highlighted through the Ten Commandments, from the lowest level of resisting jealousy all the way up to "Anochi Hashem Elokecha." In Eikev, we were reminded not to step on the "small mitzvot" (mitzvot kalot), since we don't know which mitzvot are greater in Hashem's eyes (Rashi to Devarim 7:12). In Re'eh, we were shown how to move beyond selfishness, avoid idolatry, and embrace tzedakah and generosity. In Shoftim, we came down to the practical: establishing justice, structure, and boundaries in society. Now comes Ki Tetzei, the midpoint. With its 74 mitzvot — more than any other parsha — it provides a practical checklist for daily living.

Derech Eretz as the Foundation

Pirkei Avot 3:17 teaches: "Rabbi Eliezer the son of Azariah said: If there is no Torah, there is no derech eretz; if there is no derech eretz, there is no Torah." (אם אין תורה אין דרך ארץ אם אין דרך ארץ אין תורה) Pirkei Avot (3:10) also teaches: "One who is pleasing to his fellow men, is pleasing to G-d. But one who is not pleasing to his fellow men, is not pleasing to G-d." Our parsha is filled with mitzvot that emphasize how we live with one another, not just our private service of Hashem.

The parsha opens with the laws of the captive woman (eshet yefat to'ar). The Torah recognizes that in the heat of war, human passions are inflamed. Instead of pretending this doesn't exist, the Torah regulates it. The requirement to bring her home, remove the external beauty, and wait a full month (Devarim 21:12–13, Rashi ad loc.) is not a punishment to her — it is a reset for him. It forces the soldier to step back from adrenaline and passion into calm reflection: "Am I truly choosing this relationship in reality, or was it only in the heat of the moment?" This law speaks not only to desire but to responsibility: Am I building my home on a foundation of holiness or selfishness?

Immediately afterward comes the law of the hated wife and then the rebellious son (ben sorer u'moreh). Chazal (Sanhedrin 71a) point out the progression: if one's household is built without proper love and alignment, it spirals into hatred and eventually destructive children. The Torah is not just giving laws; it is teaching us to pause and ask: What kind of home am I building?

From the Home to Society

The second aliyah emphasizes dignity even in judgment: even one executed by the court must be buried respectfully (Devarim 21:23). Then come hashavat aveidah (returning lost property) and prikah u'te'ina (helping lift a fallen animal) — mitzvot that force us to look outward and help others, even those we may not like (Rambam, Hilchot Gezeilah Va'Aveidah 11:3). We are even commanded to show compassion to animals with shiluach haken — sending away the mother bird before taking her chicks (Devarim 22:6–7). The Ramban explains this is not about the bird's feelings, but about cultivating compassion within us, training us to act with mercy in every area of life.

Then comes the mitzvah to build a ma'akeh (fence) around a roof (Devarim 22:8). Chazal see this as more than architecture: it's about creating healthy boundaries in life. It's not a wall to keep people out; it's a guardrail to protect those already inside our homes. The Gemara (Bava Kama 15b) expands this principle to every dangerous situation: we must take responsibility to remove hazards and protect others.

The Broader Checklist

As the parsha continues, we encounter mitzvot that cover almost every aspect of human life:

- Kilayim and sha'atnez — avoiding improper mixtures (Devarim 22:9–11)
- Tzitzit — constant reminders of Hashem's mitzvot (22:12, Menachot 43b)
- Giluy arayot — prohibited relationships, setting boundaries in holiness
- Moving boundary markers — respecting property and not imposing on others (Devarim 19:14, reaffirmed here)
- Justice in business — honest weights and measures (25:13–16, Rambam Hilchot Geneivah 7:1)
- Kindness to workers, converts, orphans, and widows (24:14–22)

Altogether, Ki Tetzei is like a spiritual mirror: Am I treating others with dignity? Am I acting responsibly at home and in business? Am I setting boundaries that protect life and holiness? Am I remembering the vulnerable, those who are easily forgotten, and lifting them up or am I finding the shortcuts in life to capture small pennies from others?

Preparing for Rosh Hashanah

All of this is given now, in Elul. Just as Ani L'dodi V'dodi Li (Shir HaShirim 6:3) reminds us that Hashem is close and I should be putting the wants and will of my beloved before me and my beloved will also keep my wants and will in front of her, Ki Tetzei provides the practical checklist for the cheshbon hanefesh of this month and helps me prepare for a sweeter coming year.

We are only a few weeks away from Rosh Hashanah, the day when we proclaim: "Hayom harat olam, hayom ya'amid bamishpat kol yetzurei olam" — today is the birthday of the world, today all creatures stand in judgment.

So the question Ki Tetzei pushes us to ask is: Am I living with derech eretz? Am I honoring my family, helping my fellow, caring for the vulnerable, and creating healthy boundaries in my life? Because when we do, we are not just preparing for Rosh Hashanah — we are preparing to stand before Hashem with lives that reflect His image.

Reflection Questions

- Am I treating others—family, neighbors, strangers—with the dignity they deserve?
- Where am I taking shortcuts or "capturing small pennies" at the expense of ethics?
- What healthy boundaries do I need to establish in my relationships and home?

Shabbat Shalom.

PARASHAT KI TAVO — Coming In with Gratitude

This week's parashah opens with "Ki tavo el ha'aretz" — when one comes into the land. Last week, in Ki Teitzei, we read "Ki teitzei" — when one goes out. The difference is meaningful. Going out is about facing the world, meeting its challenges and tests. Coming in is about arrival, reflection, and gratitude.

Going out focuses on action: how one behaves, treats others, and upholds Torah values under pressure. Coming in is about pausing, reflecting, and taking stock of how one has acted. It's a moment to recognize what has been achieved and to feel gratitude for the gifts and guidance that made it possible.

Bikurim — Personal Gratitude

The parashah begins with the mitzvah of Bikurim, bringing the first fruits to the Beit HaMikdash (Devarim 26:1–11). These fruits are the seven species special to Eretz Yisrael: wheat, barley, grapes, figs, pomegranates, olives, and dates (Devarim 8:7–10; Sifrei Devarim 259). The mitzvah isn't just about giving thanks in general — it's personal.

Imagine a child saying, "Thank you, Dad, for this chocolate." If the chocolate was random or purchased without thought, the thanks is polite but distant. But if the child thanks the parent for something made or carefully chosen — a meal, a snack, or a fun day planned just for them — the gratitude is personal, heartfelt, and meaningful. Bikurim works the same way: it transforms thanks into a recognition of Hashem's care and the specialness of the gifts received.

Joy is also connected to clarity. The Gemara teaches that happiness grows when doubt is removed (Berachot 31a). Midrashically, the letters of safek (ס-פ-ק) add up to the same value as Amalek (ע-מ-ל-ק): both equal 240. Doubt (safek) creates a space for Amalek to enter; removing doubt allows true joy to flourish. When there is no safek, there is joy.

Victory That Matters

The parashah reminds us that true victory isn't just about overcoming the outside world. Real success is measured by how one behaves along the way — with integrity, compassion, and restraint. Coming home after challenges isn't about survival or results alone; it's about reflecting on conduct and ethical growth.

Har Gerizim and Har Eval — Choosing Blessing

Later, the Torah describes standing on Har Gerizim and Har Eval for blessings and curses (Devarim 27). One mountain is fertile and green, the other more barren. The division teaches that blessings and warnings are real, and perspective matters.

As we explored in Parshat Re'eh, the choice between blessing and curse isn't always what it appears. Here in Ki Tavo, the lesson deepens: the experience of rebuke and reflection is deeply relational.

The Mitteler Rebbe's experience during the reading of the Tochachah illustrates this profoundly. According to Chassidic accounts, he fainted when the rebuke was read — not because the content was new, but because his father, the Alter Rebbe, was absent. Normally, the Alter Rebbe's presence provided guidance and context, allowing the teachings to be received with clarity and calm. Without that stabilizing influence, the intensity of the words was overwhelming.

This story teaches that the experience of rebuke and reflection is deeply relational. When self-examination has already been undertaken, even harsh words become constructive. Rebuke is transformed from fear into guidance, offering a path toward ethical refinement. It also reminds us that presence — guidance, mentorship, and proper context — is crucial in spiritual growth.

Gratitude for Life in Eretz Yisrael

Toward the end of the parashah, the focus turns to deep, personal gratitude — hakarat hatov — for the gift of living in Israel. There is clarity about friends and foes, and a sense of safety in knowing who one can trust. This allows for reflection and thanksgiving, especially in contrast to situations elsewhere.

Part of the blessing of Eretz Yisrael is living under a system where Torah values shape justice. The Torah recognizes that disagreements exist and that good and bad are not always clear-cut. But it strictly prohibits taking the law into one's own hands. Individuals are never judge, jury, and executioner. The Torah, especially in Parshat Shoftim (Devarim 16–17), lays out proper process, witnesses, and courts.

When we see examples — whether in our own time or throughout history — of societies where justice breaks down, where people act as their own judges, where violence replaces due process, it deepens our gratitude for a land and legal system rooted in Torah principles. For example, recently in the United States, someone was murdered simply for speaking their mind — for encouraging others to think and engage in discussion. Such tragedies remind us that the breakdown of proper justice endangers everyone.

This contrast highlights the blessing of living in a land and society where personal safety and ethical structure are supported by Torah law. It deepens gratitude for the gift of Eretz Yisrael and reinforces the lesson of Bikurim: acknowledging and celebrating the gifts that Hashem provides. The ability to live safely, reflect, and act with integrity becomes a core part of personal thanks in Ki Tavo.

Offering Personal "First Fruits"

As Elul continues and Selichot approach, the parashah encourages bringing personal "first fruits" — the best of oneself — to Hashem:

- Reflect on the past year. What went well? Where is there room to grow?
- Remove doubt (safek) by resolving unresolved conflicts or uncertainties.
- Offer personal gratitude for specific blessings: guidance, achievements, relationships, protection.
- Share gratitude with family, community, or congregation. Recognizing these gifts strengthens the connection to Hashem and makes joy tangible.

Conclusion

Ki Tavo invites reflection and gratitude. After the challenges of "going out," it is time to "come in" and take stock. Joy comes when doubt is removed, clarity prevails, and one recognizes the gifts of life. Gratitude is personal, relational, and deeply connected to everyday life. This parashah reminds that the best way to celebrate life's blessings is through awareness, integrity, and heartfelt thanks — truly bringing the "first fruits" of one's actions, reflections, and experiences back to Hashem.

Reflection Questions

- What are my personal "first fruits"—the best of what I can offer to Hashem right now?
- What doubt (safek) needs to be removed from my life to allow joy to flourish?
- Can I name three specific, personal blessings I've received this year?

PARASHAT NITZAVIM — Standing Together: Hidden Things, Revealed Responsibility

This week's parashah opens with a vivid scene: "You are all standing today before Hashem your God—your heads, your tribes, your elders, your officers, every man of Israel, your little ones, your wives, and the stranger in your camp—from the wood-chopper to the water-drawer—to enter into the covenant of Hashem your God." (אתם נצבים היום כלכם לפני ה' אלהיכם ראשיכם שבטיכם זקניכם ושטריכם כל איש ישראל טפכם נשיכם וגרך אשר בקרב מחניך מחטב עציך עד שאב מימיך) (Deut. 29:9–11)

From the highest leader to the person drawing water, every soul is present. No one is too lofty to be included, and no one is too small to matter. Hashem renews the covenant as we prepare to enter the Land, reminding us that this relationship is not only national but deeply personal.

"Why Am I Responsible?"

Many of us quietly ask this question. I'm one person. Why must my choices, my actions, carry weight for the whole? Rabbi Gerzi teaches that Jews are doers, diggers of wells. We are not meant to let the world simply happen to us; we are called to happen to the world, to carve out spaces of holiness and life-giving water wherever we stand. The covenant demands that each of us become an active participant. From this parsha and from our Rebbeim, we learn: I am responsible. I am a doer, not just a passive observer.

Who Are We Responsible For — and the Silent Tochacha

Chazal teach, "Kol Yisrael arevim zeh bazeh" (כל ישראל ערבים זה בזה) — all of Israel are guarantors for one another (Shevuot 39a). Responsibility isn't abstract. The Torah continues, "The hidden things belong to Hashem our God, but the revealed things are for us and our children forever, to do all the words of this Torah" (הנסתרת לה' אלהינו והנגלת לנו ולבנינו עד עולם) (Devarim 29:28). We are not judged for what is truly hidden, but once wrongdoing becomes public—or once we have the ability to guide someone—we share in the duty to act.

The mitzvah of tochachah (rebuke) gives this responsibility a practical framework: "You shall surely rebuke your fellow and not bear sin because of him" (הוכח תוכיח את עמיתך ולא תשא עליו חטא) (Vayikra 19:17). Chazal (Arakhin 16b) teach that true rebuke must be gentle and

constructive, aimed at helping, not humiliating. If I know how to speak in a way that might reach someone, I am obligated to try.

But tochachah is more than words. The Rambam notes that living with integrity—showing kindness, honesty, and faithfulness—is itself a silent rebuke and a model for others. How I carry myself "in the street" is often the strongest tochachah of all. Simply by acting with dignity, responsibility, and even safety (like wearing a bicycle helmet to model caution), I help lift the people around me.

Hidden and Revealed

Nitzavim acknowledges the limits of our reach: "The hidden things belong to Hashem our God, but the revealed things are for us and our children forever, to fulfill all the words of this Torah." (Deut. 29:28) If someone secretly hides an idol under the bed, that is for God alone to judge. But when wrongdoing becomes public—when it shapes the moral texture of the community—the responsibility becomes ours. The Talmud teaches, Kol Yisrael arevim zeh bazeh — all Israel are guarantors for one another (Shavuot 39a). Blessings and curses are addressed to the entire nation because covenantal life is shared life. We see this principle in the story of Rachel hiding her father Lavan's teraphim (Gen. 31). Jacob cannot be punished for what he does not know. Only the one who acts in secret faces that private judgment. But once sin is visible, silence is complicity.

Integrity of the Heart

The Torah calls us to a wholeness that spans private and public. Shiviti Hashem lenegdi tamid (שויתי ה' לנגדי תמיד) — "I place Hashem before me always" (Ps. 16:8). Whether people are watching or not, our lives must reflect God's presence. Our private selves must match the image we project in the synagogue, the workplace, or the street. Rambam (Hilchot De'ot 6:7) frames this as a mitzvah of tochachah — offering gentle, constructive guidance — because only a community of integrity can sustain the covenant.

Growth That Flows Outward

Personal growth in Torah is never only for self-perfection — it's about us growing to help others and growing with others as well. We refine ourselves so that we can lift others. Study turns into prayer; prayer flows into acts of tzedakah. As we approach Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, we repeat: Teshuvah, Tefillah, Tzedakah (תשובה תפלה וצדקה) — repentance, prayer, and righteous giving — ma'avirin et ro'a hagezeirah (מעבירין את רע הגזרה), can sweeten even a harsh decree. The flow of this is like what we have been working on throughout all of Devarim: First we turn inward with teshuvah, a self-reflection to own what I am responsible for and to make that right. Then we speak upward, asking Hashem to help make right between me and others and me and Him. Finally, we act outward with tzedakah, where my physical mitzvot impact those around me in a way where I can help, show, and elevate. Each step strengthens the covenant we all share.

The Answer — Why Am I Responsible?

Because covenant is not a contract with the crowd; it is a marriage between God and each of us, renewed in every generation. Hashem addresses kulchem — "all of you" — but also le'ovrecha (לעברך) — "that you may pass into the covenant" (Deut. 29:11), in the singular. The nation stands as one body, yet every individual is a vital organ. If even one part fails, the whole is diminished. My responsibility is not a burden but a calling: to be the well-digger, the light-bearer, the person whose private faith and public action invite blessing to the entire community.

Atem nitzavim hayom kulchem — we stand today, all of us, together. And because we stand together, my choices matter. My growth protects others, my prayer lifts others, my tzedakah sustains others. I am responsible because I am indispensable.

Reflection Questions

- How am I contributing to my community? Or am I living as though I'm disconnected?
- What "silent tochachah" am I modeling through my behavior in public?
- Where can I act today to help lift someone else?

ROSH HASHANAH — The Ladder of Return

Rosh Hashanah marks not only the beginning of a new year but the renewal of our very selves. It is the coronation of Hashem as King, yet at the same time, it is profoundly personal. The shofar's cry awakens what words cannot reach — the soul's raw yearning to come home.

Rosh Hashanah is the day we recall creation — Hayom harat olam (היום הרת עולם) — "Today the world was born." But it's also the birthday of our awareness. We step back and ask: what kind of world am I creating this year through my choices, words, and inner life?

Teshuvah — Returning to the Core

The Rambam (Hilchot Teshuvah 2:2) defines teshuvah as the moment one says, "I am no longer the person who did this." True return is not only about regret; it's about renewal — choosing to become the person Hashem always intended. The shofar's blasts — Tekiah, Shevarim, Teruah — mirror that process: clarity, brokenness, and repair. We begin whole, become fragmented, and then cry out for restoration.

The Midrash compares the shofar to the cry of a child. A parent may hear many voices, but when their own child cries, they rush instantly to comfort. So too with Hashem — the shofar breaks through the heavens not through eloquence, but through sincerity.

Coronation and Connection

We call Rosh Hashanah Yom HaZikaron — the Day of Remembrance — yet Hashem never forgets. What is remembered is not facts but relationships. Each of us is recalled before the King not as a statistic but as a beloved soul. The Machzor repeatedly says, "Zochreinu l'chaim" (זכרנו לחיים) — "Remember us for life." But Chazal teach that life here means connection — "for in You is the fountain of life" (כי עמך מקור חיים) (Tehillim 36:10). To be remembered by Hashem is to be reconnected to the Source of all being.

A Ladder Between Heaven and Earth

The Zohar describes Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur as two ends of a ladder. Rosh Hashanah is the base — the beginning of ascent, the moment we commit to climb. Yom Kippur is the top — when the light of atonement completes our return. The days between them, the Aseret Yemei Teshuvah, are the rungs. Each tefillah, each small act of kindness, each word of forgiveness lifts us higher.

Sweetness in Judgment

The Simanim — apples in honey, round challot, pomegranates — remind us that judgment and sweetness can coexist. Hashem's din is not meant to destroy but to refine. The Malbim writes that just as honey transforms bitterness into delight, so too teshuvah transforms justice into mercy. When we approach Rosh Hashanah with awe, we discover joy; when we face accountability, we find love.

Standing Before the King

The heart of Rosh Hashanah is Malchuyot — proclaiming Hashem's Kingship. The Baal Shem Tov explains that when a king enters the city, the people go out to greet him with song. Rosh Hashanah is that moment — we leave our comfort zones to meet the King in the field. The awe we feel is not fear of punishment, but reverence for being seen and chosen. Hashem's Kingship is not distant majesty; it's closeness made holy.

As we stand before Hashem this Rosh Hashanah, may the shofar's sound open our hearts to listen, our minds to remember, and our souls to return. May we be written and sealed for a year of growth, clarity, and sweetness.

Reflection Questions

- What kind of world am I creating through my choices this year?
- If I could say "I am no longer the person who did this," what would that be?
- How can I prepare to hear the shofar not just with my ears, but with my heart?

L'shanah tovah tikateivu v'teichateimu.

PARASHAT VAYELECH — Living Beyond the Self

In Parashat Vayelech, Moshe Rabbeinu prepares to take leave of this world. The Torah tells us, "Vayelech Moshe" (וילך משה) — and Moshe went." (Devarim 31:1) But where was he going? Chazal ask this question because the Torah doesn't say explicitly. Some explain that Moshe was going to the tents of Israel to say goodbye personally to each shevet, to each family. Others explain that he went simply to walk — to continue doing, even at the end, because a true leader never stops giving of himself.

Moshe says, "I am one hundred and twenty years old today; I can no longer go out and come in." (בן מאה ועשרים שנה אנכי היום לא אוכל עוד לצאת ולבוא) (31:2) Yet it wasn't that Moshe had lost physical strength — the Torah later says explicitly that his vigor had not diminished. Rather, it means his role was changing. Hashem had told him, "You shall not cross the Jordan." His mission as the leader in this world was ending, but his legacy was only beginning.

This transition — from doing to being, from leading to leaving — is one of the deepest lessons of the Torah. It teaches us that living beyond the self means recognizing that what we build through others endures longer than anything we can do alone.

Passing the Torch

Moshe calls Yehoshua and strengthens him before all Israel: "Chazak ve'ematz" (חזק ואמץ) — be strong and courageous, for you shall come with this people into the land" (31:7). Notice the wording — "you shall come with this people," not "you shall bring this people." Rashi comments that Hashem later rephrases it to Yehoshua as "you shall bring," but Moshe first uses gentler language — you will go together with them. It's a subtle act of humility and wisdom. Leadership is not domination; it's guidance. Moshe models the art of empowering another, showing that a true teacher's greatness is measured by the students who surpass him.

Writing Down the Torah

Moshe completes the writing of the Torah and commands that it be placed beside the Aron. This moment marks not only the end of Moshe's prophecy but also the transformation of Torah from oral experience to enduring text. It becomes the eternal covenant between Hashem and Israel — one that would outlast even Moshe himself. In this, Moshe demonstrates that holiness must become tangible, that inspiration must be written down and transmitted, or it risks fading away.

The Courage to Let Go

Moshe's final acts are not of conquest but of surrender. He gives over leadership, gives over Torah, and gives over his own legacy into the hands of others. And in doing so, he teaches us the secret of eternal influence — that when life is lived entirely for Hashem and for others, even death cannot end that life. The Midrash teaches that Moshe's soul left him with a kiss from

Hashem — not a tearing away, but a reunion. His humility, his total alignment with Hashem's will, made his departure as peaceful as his mission was profound.

Living Beyond the Self

Each of us faces moments when we must pass something on — our work, our teachings, our love, our example. Vayelech reminds us that greatness lies not in control but in continuity. The true measure of our lives is what remains after us — the Torah, kindness, and faith we've planted in others.

In a world obsessed with recognition, Vayelech whispers a quieter truth: what we do l'shem shamayim never ends. When we live beyond self, our name becomes eternal, not because it's written in history, but because it's inscribed in the hearts of those we've uplifted.

Reflection Questions

- What am I holding onto that I need to pass on to others?
- How can I empower someone else rather than trying to control them?
- What legacy will remain after me—in the hearts of those I've touched?

YOM KIPPUR — The Ladder of Teshuvah and the Joy of Simcha

Yom Kippur is unlike any other day in the Jewish year. It is a day of both awe and intimacy, of silence and song. We call it Yom HaKippurim — a plural form that hints, as the Zohar notes, to both the forgiveness of the day and its resemblance to Purim — a day of joy through revelation.

Throughout Yom Kippur, we repeat Vidui — confession — ten times. Each repetition corresponds to one of the ten sefirot, ten layers of divine connection. Unlike other Yamim Tovim, which have three daily tefillot plus Musaf, Yom Kippur has five: Ma'ariv, Shacharit, Musaf, Mincha, and Ne'ilah — paralleling the five levels of the soul: Nefesh, Ruach, Neshamah, Chayah, and Yechidah. As we ascend through the prayers, we peel away the layers of concealment until only the pure core remains.

Vidui — Confession and Connection

When we say "Ashamnu, Bagadnu," (אשמנו בגדנו) we are not listing crimes; we are naming distance. Each word acknowledges a place where we turned away. And in naming it, we begin to return. Rambam (Hilchot Teshuvah 1:1) writes that the essence of teshuvah is verbal confession — because speech bridges the gap between inner resolve and outer reality. When I articulate what went wrong, I transform thought into action, regret into renewal.

The Dual Nature of Yom Kippur

On the one hand, Yom Kippur is Yom HaDin — the day of judgment; on the other, it is the happiest day of the year. The Gemara (Taanit 26b) says: "There were no days as joyous for Israel as the Fifteenth of Av and Yom Kippur." (לא היו ימים טובים לישראל כחמשה עשר באב וכיום הכפורים) Why joy? Because on this day, we become transparent again — there is nothing left to hide. The barriers that separate us from Hashem fall away, and we rediscover the simplicity of being loved.

White Garments and Wholeness

We wear white on Yom Kippur to resemble the angels, but also to reflect purity in potential. White is not the absence of color; it is the harmony of all colors in balance. So too Yom Kippur is not the absence of life's complexity; it is its full alignment under the light of Hashem. The Kohen Gadol entered the Kodesh HaKodashim wearing simple white linen, representing humility — the ability to approach Hashem with nothing but sincerity.

The Joy of Ne'ilah

The final tefillah, Ne'ilah, is not closure — it is culmination. The gates of heaven are not closing on us; we are closing ourselves in with Hashem. In that final moment, when we cry "Shema Yisrael, Hashem Elokeinu, Hashem Echad," it is not repetition but revelation. We have climbed the ladder from separation to unity. From fear to love. From confession to connection.

After the final Tekiah Gedolah, we do not collapse — we dance. Because teshuvah, when complete, leads to joy. The Rambam (Hilchot Teshuvah 7:6) writes that those who return out of love transform their sins into merits. The very falls that once distanced us now become the steps that lift us higher.

May we merit that our teshuvah this Yom Kippur be not only a cleansing but a rebirth — a return to the simplicity of the soul, where joy and awe, like judgment and mercy, are one.

Reflection Questions

- What distance have I created between myself and Hashem this year?
- Can I name what I need to confess—not as guilt, but as honest acknowledgment?
- What would it feel like to stand before Hashem with nothing left to hide?

PARASHAT HAAZINU — The Song of Listening

As we near the end of the Torah, Parashat Haazinu stands as Moshe Rabbeinu's poetic farewell — a song of both warning and love, rebuke and hope. It is not simply words of

prophecy; it is a song because truth, when sung, transcends the limits of intellect and touches the heart.

The parasha opens: "Haazinu hashamayim va'adabeirah, vetishma ha'aretz imrei fi — Give ear, O heavens, and I will speak; and let the earth hear the words of my mouth." (Devarim 32:1) Moshe calls on heaven and earth to serve as witnesses. They are eternal — unlike man — and will always be present to testify that Hashem's covenant endures. But there is also a deeper message here. The heavens represent the spiritual, lofty ideals, while the earth represents the practical, grounded actions. Together they encompass all of life. Haazinu teaches us that the purpose of Torah is to unify both: to make the heavenly audible on earth, to live spirituality in practice.

Listening and Hearing

Moshe uses two different verbs: haazinu (give ear) and tishma (hear). Rashi notes that haazinu refers to listening up close, while tishma suggests hearing from afar. For Moshe, who is close to the heavens, the "listening" is intimate; for the people, rooted in the earth, it is hearing from a distance. Yet both are connected through Torah — the bridge between divine truth and human reality.

Rebuke and Compassion

The song recounts Israel's journey: Hashem's kindness, Israel's rebellion, and Hashem's enduring mercy. "He found them in a desert land… He encircled them, cared for them, guarded them like the pupil of His eye" (ימצאהו בארץ מדבר... יסבבנהו יבוננהו יצרנהו כאישון עינו) (32:10). Even when the people stray, Hashem's protection never fully departs. The rebuke of Haazinu is not meant to crush but to awaken. It is the song of a parent whose love is fierce and eternal, whose disappointment stems from longing, not rejection.

Avodah Zarah Revisited

The recurring theme of Sefer Devarim — the danger of avodah zarah — appears here again, but in musical form. "They provoked Me with alien gods; with abominations they angered Me" (יקנאני בלא אל כעסוני בהבליהם) (32:16). On the surface, these are the sins of idolatry, but spiritually, they represent misplaced trust — in wealth, in power, in self. Moshe's song reveals the root of all avodah zarah: forgetting gratitude, forgetting dependence, forgetting that all sustenance flows from Hashem. The moment we say, "My strength made this," the song falters.

The Balance of Justice and Mercy

"See now that I, I am He, and there is no god with Me; I kill and I give life, I wound and I heal" (ראו עתה כי אני אני הוא ואין אלהים עמדי אני אמית ואחיה מחצתי ואני ארפא) (32:39). The Sifrei explains: Hashem is not two forces — one for good and one for evil — but One. Both judgment and

compassion emanate from the same Source. This is the Torah's ultimate message against dualism. Every event in life, sweet or bitter, is part of one divine harmony.

Haazinu as Personal Reflection

Each of us has our own Haazinu — our personal song, the story of where we've seen Hashem's kindness, where we've fallen, and how we've returned. Moshe's song is not only about the nation; it's about the individual journey from distance to closeness, from pride to humility, from self to surrender.

Hearing as Believing

When Bnei Yisrael accepted the Torah, they said, "Na'aseh v'nishma" (נעשה ונשמע) — "We will do, and we will hear." In Haazinu, Moshe echoes that same ideal. Real faith is not blind doing nor detached understanding; it is the harmony of both. Hearing leads to action, and action deepens hearing. It is the cycle of teshuvah itself.

As Moshe's words conclude, he reminds the people that Torah is not just lofty wisdom: "For it is not an empty thing for you, for it is your life" (כי לא דבר רק הוא מכם כי הוא חייכם) (32:47). Torah is the song of existence — it animates every breath, every moment. To forget it is to lose the melody of life itself.

Reflection Questions

- What is my personal "song"—where have I seen Hashem's kindness and where have I fallen?
- Am I listening closely (haazinu) or only hearing from afar (tishma)?
- Can I see both the sweet and bitter events of my life as part of one divine harmony?

SUKKOT — The Makom Kadosh of Bitul and Equality

We have made it through the first half of Chodesh Tishrei — through Rosh Hashanah, Aseret Yemei Teshuvah, and Yom Kippur. Before that came Elul, and before that Av — months of introspection, accounting, and renewal. Each period brought its own reckoning: Who am I? Where am I? What is my value within Klal Yisrael? We have spent weeks confronting ourselves, striving to peel away layers of ego and error, to return fully through teshuvah sheleimah.

And now, after all of that awe and seriousness, Hashem gives us something that seems almost surprising: to go outside, live in a hut for seven days, and shake together four species of plants. After such intensity, it feels almost whimsical — but in truth, it is profoundly deep.

From Awe to Bitul

A friend once expressed it beautifully: when we all sit in the sukkah, we enter a space of bitul, of dissolving the self. The sukkah is a makom kadosh, a holy space, not because of grandeur but because of simplicity. We leave our homes — symbols of permanence and ego — and dwell in fragility. The schach lets in sunlight and starlight, reminding us that what shelters us is not our craftsmanship but Hashem's presence.

Unity and Equality

The sukkah is the great equalizer. The wealthy man and the pauper, the scholar and the simple Jew — all sit under the same type of roof. Just as the ananei hakavod surrounded all Israel equally, so too the sukkah embraces every Jew without distinction. In that space, we return to the pure awareness that our worth comes not from possessions or status, but from being creations of Hashem.

The Arba Minim — A Symbol of Oneness

The lulav, etrog, hadas, and aravah represent different kinds of Jews: those with Torah and good deeds, those with one or neither. But the mitzvah is only fulfilled when they are bound together. No single species can complete the mitzvah alone. The message is clear: holiness is collective. Klal Yisrael's beauty is in its diversity unified under Hashem.

Joy After Atonement

After Yom Kippur's cleansing comes Sukkot's joy — Zman Simchateinu. Joy is the natural state of a soul aligned with truth. Having stripped away the layers of ego through teshuvah, we can now celebrate simplicity: life itself, air, light, community, Torah.

The Simplicity of Joy — Shabbat Chol HaMoed Sukkot

I was walking home from a friend's sukkah, and as I wished a neighbor a Chag Sameach, he replied in kind — then asked me a great question: "Why is Sukkot called the time of our joy?" The Torah commands us to rejoice — "V'samachta b'chagecha" — but why now, after such awe and fasting? The answer lies in the essence of the water libation — the Nisuch HaMayim. Unlike the wine offering, which symbolizes complexity and struggle, water is simple, essential, life-giving, and accessible to all. That is why the Simchat Beit HaSho'eva — the water-drawing celebration — was the most joyous event in the Temple. Water represents Torah itself — "Ein mayim ela Torah."

The Cost of Water and the Cost of Torah

Water costs nothing yet sustains everything. It falls from heaven, filling all crevices equally. Torah, too, flows freely for anyone who humbles himself to receive it. Those who seek it with simplicity — without pretense or intellectual arrogance — are filled with life. In the days of the

Beit HaMikdash, the water drawing was a prayer for rain, but also a symbol of this truth: we draw down blessing only through humility.

Torah and Water in Daily Life

The joy of Torah is not found only in deep, mystical analysis but also in the simple pshat — the clear water that quenches daily thirst. Like drinking from a spring, we can flavor it with layers of remez, drash, and sod, but the foundation is always the pure source. If I lose the simplicity of Torah, I lose its life-giving essence.

Sukkot reminds us that joy and holiness are not distant ideals. They are found in gratitude, simplicity, and unity. The sukkah teaches us to let go of control; the water teaches us to let go of ego. Together they draw us back to the core of emunah — that Hashem provides, sustains, and loves us.

May the joy of Sukkot flow into our year ahead, refreshing our souls like living water, and may our homes, hearts, and sukkot all become makom kadosh — spaces of holiness and joy.

Reflection Questions

- What "permanent dwelling" do I need to step out of to remember what truly shelters me?
- Who in my community represents a different "species"—and how can I bind together with them?
- How can I embrace simplicity and let go of ego this week?

CONCLUSION

From the opening words of Devarim to the final celebrations of Sukkot, we have traveled a complete journey of the soul. We began with memory and responsibility, confronted our inner idolatries, learned to value the small and the overlooked, opened our eyes to blessing, established boundaries and structure, created practical checklists for living, returned home with gratitude, stood together in covenant, and finally — after the awe of the Yamim Nora'im — celebrated the joy that comes from complete alignment with Hashem's will.

This is not merely a journey through the calendar. It is the map of teshuvah itself: from self-awareness to self-transcendence, from ego to emunah, from isolation to unity, from complexity to simplicity.

Living These Teachings

How do we carry this journey forward into our daily lives? Here are some practical ways to integrate what we've learned:

From Devarim - Memory as Inheritance

- Keep a journal of your spiritual journey. What patterns repeat? What have you learned?
- Share your family's stories with the next generation — the struggles and the victories
- Don't sanitize your past; learn from it honestly

From Va'etchanan - Climbing the Ladder

- When you feel jealousy or anger, pause and ask: "What am I placing between myself and Hashem?"
- Practice saying Shema with intention, expanding the word "Echad" to feel Hashem's unity in all directions
- Work backwards from your highest aspirations: what small step can you take today?

From Eikev - Noticing the Small

- Choose one "small" mitzvah you've been overlooking and bring it into consciousness
- Practice awareness in mundane moments: tying your shoes, drinking water, opening a door
- Value the "small" people in your life — who have you been stepping over?

From Re'eh - Seeing Blessing

- Practice reframing: when something appears as a "curse," ask what hidden blessing it might contain
- Give tzedakah regularly, even small amounts, to remember that everything comes from Hashem
- Keep a gratitude list of specific, personal gifts from Hashem

From Shoftim - Structure and Holiness

- Create boundaries in your life that protect kedushah (a ma'akeh for your "roof")
- Examine your leadership: are you empowering others or controlling them?
- Find ways to bring holiness into the ordinary structures of your day

From Ki Tetzei - The Daily Checklist

- Review your derech eretz: how do you treat family, neighbors, employees, strangers?
- Practice compassion even toward those you don't like (hashavat aveidah, prikah u'te'ina)
- Build healthy boundaries in your relationships and home

From Ki Tavo - Returning with Gratitude

- Offer your "first fruits" — the best of your time, energy, and resources — to Hashem
- Remove doubt (safek) by resolving conflicts and seeking clarity
- Express specific, personal gratitude regularly

From Nitzavim - Standing Responsible

- Remember: your choices affect the whole community — act accordingly
- Practice "silent tochachah" by living with integrity
- Ask yourself: what can I do today that will help lift someone else?

From the Yamim Nora'im - Renewal and Joy

- Don't wait for Rosh Hashanah to begin again — every day offers a chance to return
- Practice confession (vidui) not as guilt but as honest acknowledgment
- After working on yourself, celebrate — joy is the sign of true alignment

From Sukkot - Simplicity and Unity

- Regularly step outside your "permanent dwelling" — physically or metaphorically — to remember what really shelters you
- Seek out the "four species" in your community — people different from you who complete the picture
- Draw down blessing through humility, like water from a spring

A Final Reflection

As we complete this cycle and prepare to begin again with Bereishit, we carry forward everything we have learned. We have seen that holiness is not escape from the world but full presence within it. We have learned that the small matters as much as the great, that giving breaks the chains of idolatry, that responsibility is love made tangible, and that joy is the natural state of a soul aligned with truth.

May we merit to live these lessons throughout the coming year — to see Hashem's hand in every moment, to give generously, to act with integrity, to embrace our responsibilities with joy, and to transform every aspect of our lives into vessels for kedushah.

From self to surrender. From Devarim to Simchat Torah. From year to year, growing closer to the Source of all blessings.